called The Living Room. Usually, it was friendly enough, and was somewhere we went regularly because people knew us but left us to get on with our meal. That afternoon, though, Dave and I strolled in and it was like that scene in the Western where the guy walks into the wrong saloon in Deadwood Gulch. People turned round and stared daggers. It was pretty unnerving. We slunk over into a corner and just buried our heads in the menu.

'I'm not coming out with you again, mate,' Dave whispered. 'It's more than my life's worth.'

For the next few months, we used to joke about getting fitted up in bullet-proof undershirts and crash helmets before we left the house. You had to find a way of laughing about it just to keep the tension at arms' length.

On the soccer side, the manager didn't need to say much. We knew what we had to do: make up for the underachievement of the year before. That hadn't been good enough for us, for the club or for the supporters. We knew 1998/99 was going to have to be a big season. Even more so for me personally: I went into it with the feeling that, in the aftermath of the World Cup, this was make or break for me, at least as far as playing in England was concerned.

For the first Premiership game of the new season, we were at home to Leicester City. I don't think I've ever been as nervous before a soccer match as I was that afternoon. I'd always had a good relationship with the crowd at Old Trafford, but what reaction would I get now? I wasn't sure how I was going to respond either. The last time I'd played a really competitive game had been in Saint-Etienne. There was this little nagging uncertainty in the back of my mind that morning: how did I know that what had happened against Argentina wouldn't happen again? It wasn't as if I understood exactly why I'd reacted to Simeone's antics: I didn't know now, for sure, if I'd be able stop myself getting into the same situation again. I didn't have the experience back then to realize that I was a relatively immature person who, as a player, was just burning up with the desire to win games. I was desperate to kick off against Leicester but I was dreading those ninety minutes too.

There were more than the ninety to play, as it turned out. The home fans were fantastic to me that afternoon. Every time I went to take a corner, thousands of them stood up to cheer for me. They wanted me to know they were behind me. And that meant so much. It was an amazing feeling. With 60,000 United fans on your side, you're ready to take on the rest of the world. The game, though, had a twist: we were 2–0 down at half time. Teddy